

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'Sandalwood Limb'

Ārya-candanāṅgā-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 518 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཙན་གྱིན་ལག་ཅེ་བ་བྱའི་གཟུངས།

Toh 518 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in English as "The Noble Sandalwood Limb," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-candanāṅgā-nāma-dhāraṇī, and in Tibetan as Pakpa Tsendan Yangkyi Zhukpa Shyejawa'i Zungwa. It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur, a class of texts centered on the preservation and recitation of sacred ritual formulas believed to confer protection and spiritual benefit. The text opens with a standard sūtra framing, presenting the Buddha dwelling at Rājagṛha amid a vast assembly of monks, bodhisattvas, and gods, before addressing the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, suggesting the dhāraṇī is closely associated with this bodhisattva's compassionate activity. The text was translated into Tibetan by the monk Yeshé Dé and subsequently revised in accordance with the standardized imperial terminology established during Tibet's early translation period.

— and the great editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, translated and edited this text, and it was finalized through the new standardization of terminology.

In the language of India: Ārya-candanāṅgā-nāma-dhāraṇī.

In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Sandalwood Limb."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in Rājagṛha together with a great Saṅgha of monks — a great monastic Saṅgha of twelve thousand five hundred monks — and with very many great bodhisattvas, and also together with many distinguished gods. Then the Blessed One, by the miraculous power (Skt. vikurvita) of a Tathāgata, sat upon the prepared seat in radiant, serene, and majestic splendor.

The Blessed One then addressed the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and the youth Moonlight in that assembly, saying: "Sons of good family, beyond this world-realm, further still beyond its far side, past world-realms as numerous as the grains of sand in countless Ganges rivers — multiplied by hundreds of thousands of tens of millions — there exists a world-realm called Sandalwood Splendor. There dwells a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Sandalwood Limb, present right now, alive and abiding, who also teaches the Dharma. All the sentient beings of that world-realm are

destined, without exception, to become irreversible. That Blessed One — the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha Sandalwood Limb — has, for the sake of all sentient beings, proclaimed this foundational vidyā-mantra of the dhāraṇī called 'Sandalwood Limb.' Those who are irreversible and hear this are freed from wrongdoing and are never separated from the awakening mind.

"The Blessed One Tathāgata Amitāyus, the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara (Lamp-maker), the Tathāgata Vairocana, and also the buddhas and blessed ones of the past have likewise proclaimed this before. I too shall explain it to you. Listen well and take it to heart, for the sake of embracing all sentient beings. In this latter time, in the final five-hundred-year period, when the sublime Dharma is declining — when all are devoid of Dharma, when those who commit the acts of immediate retribution appear, who revile the sublime Dharma, who demolish stūpas, who steal the property of the Saṅgha, who falsely claim to be śramaṇas (renunciants) though they are not, and who abandon their ācāryas and preceptors — for the sake of embracing such beings, I shall now proclaim this foundational mantra of the dhāraṇī of Sandalwood Limb, which has been blessed by all the buddhas. Bodhisattvas, listen to me."

Then the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and the youth Moonlight bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One in homage and requested him: "Out of compassion for the great bodhisattvas and for beings numbering in the hundreds of thousands of tens of millions, and for the purification of wrongdoing, may the Blessed One please speak. May the Sugata please speak. May the Tathāgata please speak. We too shall take up and hold these foundational mantras of the dhāraṇī and expound them widely and correctly for the benefit of all sentient beings."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

tadyathā: cirāte māricīki durdame durdānate duranu praviṣṭe candanāṅgaze
samantapariśodhani viśuddhaśīle caritravate anacedya-pratibhāne
sarvabuddhādhiṣṭhite bhagavate pāpakṣayaṃ āśāme paripūraya svāhā.

Sons of good family, whether male or

daughters of good family who take up, recite, teach, or make perfectly complete these foundational mantras of the great dhāraṇī — in that very lifetime their eyes will become completely purified. The moment they hear it, they will be thoroughly liberated from wrongdoing. They will be blessed by all

the bodhisattvas. They will behold the form-bodies of the Tathāgatas. If they recite it for half a month, they will behold the noble Avalokiteśvara and the youthful Candraprabha. Even the wrongdoing of the five acts of immediate retribution will be cleansed. They will remember their former lives. After passing from this life they will be reborn among the gods. They will be reborn into the households of great and joyful householders. All beings will rejoice in them.

It may be possible that the entire great earth without remainder crumbles. It may be possible that the ocean dries up. Likewise, it may be possible that Mount Meru, the king of mountains, is destroyed. It may be possible that the wind is bound with a lasso. It may be possible that the moon and sun fall upon the ground. It may be possible that the sky is pressed down by two hands. It may be possible that fire turns to water. It may be possible that the four great elements become something other than what they are. It may be possible that the minds of all sentient beings become one. Yet what has been spoken and blessed by the Tathāgata cannot become otherwise — no one is able to move it or shake it. The evil māra cannot find an opening against this.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, prostrated to the Blessed One and spoke these words: "Blessed One, I too shall explain the ritual of this dhāraṇī. Before a stūpa of the Dharma-king containing relics, or before an image of a buddha, one should make a maṇḍala of white sandalwood, strew loose flowers upon it, offer incense of sandalwood, and, beginning from the first day of the month until the fifteenth, bathe three times each day and change one's robes three times. One should seek out food that has been purified by fire and observe the restoration ceremony. With a mind of equanimity toward all sentient beings, on the day of the new moon one should fast for a single day, remain on a cushion of grass, and lying upon the spread grass recite with one-pointed mind. One should scatter fragrant flowers one thousand times, and the flowers will move. I myself will behold the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, and Avalokiteśvara. The moment one hears the great dhāraṇī, whatever one wishes will be obtained. One will also gain the power of retention. All karmic obscurations will be purified."

After the Blessed One had spoken thus, those monks, those bodhisattvas, that entire assembled retinue together with gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced, and with delight praised what the Blessed One had declared.

The noble dhāraṇī called The Limb of Sandalwood is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end with "Sons of good family, whether male or" — this is simply where the supplied passage ends; the sentence continues in the source text beyond what was provided.

The Tibetan rendering of Dīpaṃkara (ལྷོ་མཚོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཚོ་མཆོག་) literally means "maker of lamps / torch-maker," which is the standard Tibetan equivalent of this well-known buddha's name; the Sanskrit is supplied for clarity.

The mantra syllables are transcribed as they appear in the Tibetan transliteration; no normalization has been attempted, as mantra orthography is traditionally preserved as received.

The phrase rendered "foundational vidyā-mantra" translates རྩོམ་མཚན་ལྷོ་མཚོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཚོ་མཆོག་, which literally means "the base of the mantra of vidyā of the dhāraṇī" — a compound indicating the root or foundation text of the mantra-dhāraṇī. "Foundational vidyā-mantra" captures both the sense of primacy and the vidyā element without over-paraphrasing.

- The "five acts of immediate retribution" refers to the five ānantarya-karmas: matricide, patricide, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing schism in the Saṅgha. These are the gravest of karmic acts, bringing rebirth in hell without interval.

The term rendered "food purified by fire" (Tibetan: kha zas bsreg bya) indicates food that has been properly prepared or purified through cooking, a ritual dietary restriction common in sādhana contexts.

"Candraprabha" (Tibetan: zla 'od gzhon nur gyur pa, literally "he who has become the youthful Moonlight") is a standard epithet of the bodhisattva Candraprabha, here a companion figure to Avalokiteśvara.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.